

Commonwealth Championships in New Delhi, where her bronze medal-clinching campaign in women's singles included a victory over top seed Yangzi Liu of Australia, an opponent she had lost to in the UTT.

On the other hand, Abhinandh, called 'giant slayer' by commentators, took down higher-ranked opponents in his first four matches this season — Lilian Bardet, 3-0; Payas Jain, 2-1; Ankur Bhattacharjee, 2-1; Youssef Abdel-Aziz, 3-0. He later suffered his first loss to Omar Assar, the highest-ranked male paddler this edition. The Chennai teen seemed to have lost some momentum before bagging a crucial game off his senior and state-mate, G. Sathiyam, and then beating Bardet again in the final.

The 18-year-old attributed the fearlessness of the new generation to the changing nature of the sport. "The modern game is aggressive. If you look at the sport 10 years ago, it was a different ball game. Even the new generation coming out of China and Japan are all attacking players. That's the way the modern game is, and that's how I'm trying to adapt," he said.

Former Olympian and UTT Ambassador Sharath Kamal also weighed in, saying the mindset had evolved over generations, with increased international exposure and consistency across the junior and youth categories playing a key role.

"Not that they [younger players] lack respect, but they're fearless and know they can beat anybody. During my time, I could clearly see that my peers, or the generation right after me, could never think of beating me. Then came the generation of Sathiyam, Harmeet Desai and Soumyajit Ghosh, who thought, 'If we need to do well, we need to beat Sharath.' That was the target, and they were quite open about it. And now you see the Manav and Manush generation, who are like, 'We can probably beat the best in the country, but probably also the best in the world,'" Sharath said.

The Indian youngsters stood tall, matching the world's best shoulder to shoulder. But were the foreigners

really the world's best?

Rankings-wise, UTT has only briefly welcomed top-10 players. In the inaugural season, Wong Chun Ting of Hong Kong was World No. 7. In the second, France's Simon Gauzy was World No. 8. Since then, Romanian paddler Bernadette Szocs has been the highest-ranked player, male or female, over the last three seasons.

This trend of not many from the crème de la crème of world table tennis coming to India has a lot to do with the sustainability of UTT, Sharath felt.

"Let's say a top-10 player comes and a lot of people turn up to watch. That would add more commercial value to the league, but I don't think that has happened until now. Of course, it's something they'll be looking at now that Butterfly has come on board. It has a lot to do with the sustainability of the league. There have been other leagues, like the T2 Asia Pacific tournament, which had these top players, but they didn't sustain themselves beyond a couple of years. It's also very difficult to get dates from them when they're constantly playing WTT Champions events," he explained.

But the former India international also added that the current Indian paddlers had closed the gap on these foreign players, which has only improved the quality of the game on the table.

"We've also become that level, right? When UTT started, our average rank was somewhere around 150-200. Now, it's around the 40s and 50s," Sharath said.

New tech, and the future

One notable change in an otherwise unchanging league this time around was the introduction of the Table Tennis Review (TTR). The technology's debut largely earned plaudits from players across the franchises, barring one controversy during the league-stage fixture between Dabang Delhi and Pune Jaguars where Diya Chitale was awarded a point for an obstruction in play by Sutirtha Mukherjee. Some argued that this didn't come under the purview of TTR; some said it should.

Top-ranked players in each UTT edition



2017

Wong Chun Ting (Hong Kong - World No. 7)

2018

Simon Gauzy (France - World No. 8)

2019

Chuang Chih-yuan (Chinese Taipei - World No. 28)

2023

Quadri Aruna (Nigeria - World No. 16)

2024

Bernadette Szocs (Romania - World No. 12) and Quadri Aruna (Nigeria - World No. 12)

2025

Bernadette Szocs (Romania - World No. 13)

2026

Bernadette Szocs (Romania - World No. 24)

Even Jigar Rambhia, Competition Director, said that the league will try to add more instances to TTR's gamut going forward.

After seven seasons, is there a chance of adding more teams to the league's roster? Dani didn't seem too interested, instead reasserting her faith in the current model.

"I think it [UTT amidst franchise owner changes] has settled. I don't think we would want more franchisees coming in. I just think it would become too long a league. I would like to stick to the current model first and test it further, see how we can make it profitable for everybody, and then worry about expanding. Of course, if more people are willing to come into the game, they are welcome," she said.